



ShabbaTTogether

Mental Health Guide for Community Shluchim Playbook

Created in 2023. Not adapted for Covid-19 Crisis.

Introduction

Mental Health conditions affect millions of Americans each year. **One in twenty** Americans have experienced a mental health condition, and **one in 25** adults has experienced a serious mental condition. There is growing awareness and momentum within the general culture to address mental health challenges such as anxiety, depression and mood disorders openly. This means that more than ever, Shluchim and Shluchos need to focus not only on congregants' spiritual growth, but also on their emotional well-being. This guide outlines current trends in mental health and substance abuse among adults, recommends the appropriate role of the Shluchim and Shluchos, and offers steps to manage referrals to professionals when indicated.

Mental Health Overview

Mental health among adults, especially young adults, is a growing concern. According to NAMI, here are a few facts:¹

- **1 in 5** U.S. adults experience a mental condition each year
- **1 in 25** U.S. adults experience a serious mental condition each year
- **1 in 6** U.S. youth aged 6-17 experience a mental health condition each year
- Suicide is the **2nd leading** cause of death among people aged 10-34²

¹Mental Health By the Numbers. NAMI. <https://www.nami.org/Learn-More/Mental-Health-By-the-Numbers>

²Risk of Suicide. NAMI <https://www.nami.org/Learn-More/Mental-Health-Conditions/Related-Conditions/Suicide>

- Across the U.S. economy, serious mental health conditions causes **\$193.2 billion** in lost earnings each year

Many reasons have been suggested for these alarming trends, including excessive use and abuse of social media, cyberbullying, and more. Our goal is not to analyze the roots of the problem but rather to help Shluchim and Shluchos recognize and assist congregants with these or other mental health conditions, including relationship issues, family issues, grief, trauma, mood instability, gender identity, self-injury, and eating disorders.

Substance Abuse

Mental health issues and substance abuse often go hand in hand. Each has its own unique symptoms that impede a person's ability to function properly. When a mental health condition goes untreated, the substance abuse problem usually gets worse. And when alcohol or drug abuse increases, mental health problems usually increase as well. According to recent research by the National Institute of Health,

- First-Time Treatment Admissions for Primary Opioid Use Disorder (OUD) in Adults Age 55 and Older Have Almost Doubled Since 2007 In contrast, in people under age 55, admissions for first-time opioid use disorder treatment have increased steadily since 2007 at a rate of about 10 percent per year.³
- About half of those who experience a mental illness during their lives will also experience a substance use disorder and vice versa.⁴

What is the Shliach's Role?

As a Shliach or Shlucha, you are a friend, rabbi/rebbetzin, mentor, educator, spiritual guide, listening ear, and trusted advisor. You are not a social worker, therapist, psychologist, psychiatrist, substance abuse counselor, or other mental health professional unless you are trained and licensed. Only a mental health professional can make a diagnosis.

3

<https://www.drugabuse.gov/news-events/nida-notes/2019/07/drug-use-its-consequences-increase-among-middle-aged-older-adults>

4

<https://www.drugabuse.gov/publications/research-reports/common-comorbidities-substance-use-disorders/part-1-connection-between-substance-use-disorders-mental-illness>

As much as you may wish to help a congregant struggling with emotional issues or substance abuse, or as much as that congregant expects you to help them, there is a limit to what you alone can accomplish. By overstepping your role, you are endangering both the congregant and yourself. The congregant is hurt by not getting the necessary professional help, and you could possibly face legal ramifications. Rather, your responsibility is to:

1. Cultivate relationships with mental health professionals
2. Destigmatize your congregants need for help
3. Identify people at risk
4. Refer them to the appropriate resource(s)
5. Continue to provide caring support and encouragement

Destigmatize Mental Health Conditions

Encourage congregants to take care of their emotional health and not be embarrassed to seek professional help. Convey the message that just as it is accepted and praiseworthy to work out in a gym to strengthen one's body, or to seek medical attention for a physical condition, it is important and healthy to care for one's emotional well-being.

*Include these messages in your speeches when applicable.

Recognize Congregants at Risk

In many cases, it is obvious when a congregant's problems are beyond your scope. Often, there is a "gray area." Learn to recognize early those who are at the highest risk and most vulnerable:

- If a congregant is excessively needy or develops an unhealthy dependency upon you, it's time to guide them towards professional help.
- Don't wait until a situation escalates into a crisis.
- If a congregant does seem to be in crisis, help them get immediate attention.
- Improve your understanding of the issues by attending workshops or one-day training sessions in Mental Health First Aid or similar courses.
- Host your own **SafeTalk training**, provided FREE to Shluchim. Contact info@shabbattogether.com to schedule a **FREE** training.

Cultivate Relationships with Mental Health Professionals

Develop a rapport with at least one mental health professional, such as a person in your community or a board member who can help you navigate challenging situations as they arise.

Provide Continued Support

- Ask the congregant how you can help.
- Help can include: visiting; encouraging others to visit; bringing food; staying in touch by phone or text.
- Continue to welcome the congregant to Chabad House, unless his/her behavior poses a danger to himself or others, or otherwise creates a situation that is not sustainable for you or your community. This is a decision not to be made lightly, and should be made in conjunction with input from a mental health professional.
- Know your community resources for people who are in a crisis or need assistance and make referrals as appropriate.

The Importance of Self-Care

As a Shliach or Shlucha, it is important for you to look after your own mental health and well-being so that you can more effectively care for the people you work with. The concept of self-care is similar to the safety procedures on an aircraft that require you to fit your own oxygen mask before attending to others in the event of an emergency. By taking care of yourself, you can fulfill your role more effectively, maintain your confidence and achieve satisfaction from your work. Try to:

- Engage in activities that give you energy, lower your stress and contribute to your physical and emotional well-being.
- Engage in ongoing peer-support.
- Recognize when your physical or emotional well-being is compromised.
- Seek intervention before your stress level gets too high.

Warning Signs of Burnout

As a Shliach or Shlucha, the demands of your role can significantly affect your physical and emotional well-being. It is important for you to notice the signs of burnout before they overwhelm you and compromise your ability to effectively help others. Signs can include:

- Small issues produce strong emotional reactions
- Chronic low energy and exhaustion
- Getting sick more frequently
- Can't forgo perfection
- Having a sense of inefficacy

- Feeling overwhelmed and disengaged
- Enthusiasm for your work has faded

The Importance of Healthy Boundaries

As a Shliach or Shlucha, people will be turning to you for guidance and support in times of personal crisis. People will come to rely on you and you will want to help everyone all of the time. Having guidelines, rules and limits will help you to identify safe and acceptable ways for other people to behave towards you and will help you to respect the emotional and physical boundaries of the individuals you assist.

Proper self-care and maintaining healthy boundaries can also help to alleviate burnout.

Setting boundaries does not always come easily. To start setting your boundaries, consider these two categories:

Know Your Limits

- Determine what your emotional, physical, and spiritual boundaries are with individuals who turn to you for guidance.
 - Emotional - You may experience those who turn to you for help as vulnerable, manipulative, confrontational or selfish.
 - Physical - You may feel threatened or overburdened when people do not respect your personal space or value your time.
 - Spiritual - You may feel like your religious values are being compromised as you labor to help others.
- Examine past experiences where you felt discomfort, anger, resentment or frustration with an individual.

Be Assertive

- Inform others of your boundaries and alert them when your boundaries have been crossed.
- To avoid experiencing negative emotions and burnout consider limiting your availability.
- Seek guidance from peers and advisors when you suspect your boundaries have been crossed.

Pay Attention To Your Spouse and Children

As a Shliach or Shlucha, it is important that you recognize the affect your work is having on your spouse and children. Your family is susceptible to negative reactions and burnout, too.

Pay attention to signs of frustration, alienation, sadness, anger, resentment or exhaustion in your spouse or children and remember to attend to the well-being of your family while you care for the wellness of others.

Resources

Free Professional telephone support for Shluchim



Malka Blicblum is available as a **FREE resource** for all shluchim as a mental health professional. She is a certified professional addiction recovery coach (CPARC) and is available for confidential consults, referrals and guidance in any area of mental wellness. She WILL NOT CHARGE FOR ONGOING SERVICES FOR SHLUCHIM! She can be reached at 813-651-0201 or sbmdpa@aol.com.

Editable Resource Handout:

[CLICK HERE to edit and for instructions.](#)

Local Resources

Jewish Family Services, Recommended Clinics, Therapists, Psychiatrists, University Mental Health Programs

Mental Health Resources Locator
www.MentalHealth.gov

Psychology Today Therapists Local Listings
www.psychologytoday.com/us/therapists

Local NAMI Chapter Location: www.nami.org

National Resources

The following are examples of the many resources available including those that support Jewish individuals and families. The RCJ does not endorse any of these organizations.

Mental Health National Alliance on Mental Illness (NAMI) www.nami.org Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration (SAMHSA) www.samhsa.gov Mental Health Relief provides mental health referrals, education and support to the Jewish community worldwide www.reliefhelp.org	Addiction 12 Steps Program www.12stepsprogram.com Alcoholics Anonymous www.aa.org JACS - Jewish Alcoholics, Chemical Dependency, Support for Jewish alcoholics and chemically dependent persons and their families 212-432-4800 jacs@jacs.org	Offers anonymous intervention, provider care referrals, 24 hour support, 12 step groups and more www.guardyourjes.com Family Member Support Al-Anon and Alateen www.al-anon.org NAMI Family Members and Caregivers www.nami.org
Suicide Prevention If you or someone you know is in an emergency, call 911 immediately. National Suicide Prevention Lifeline at 800-273-TALK (8255) suicidepreventionlifeline.org	Amudim - Referrals, crisis intervention, education and awareness for substance abuse and addiction 646-577-5222 www.amudim.org The Guard Your Eyes Network for From Recovery: Assists those struggling with compulsive use of inappropriate materials and related behaviors.	Domestic Violence and Abuse Shalom Task Force - Dedicated to helping Jewish individuals and families struggling in troubled or abusive relationships. Confidential Anonymous Hotline: 718-327-3700 or 888-883-2323 http://www.shalomtaskforce.org

ShabbatTogether
www.ShabbatTogether.com

USEFUL LINKS

Network of Jewish Human Service Agencies

Locator for Jewish Family Service agencies in the USA

<https://www.networkjhsa.org/agency-locator/>

Refuat HaNefesh. An excellent Jewish resource providing information and resources on mental health conditions and support. :

<https://www.refuathanefesh.org>

National Alliance on Mental Health (NAMI)

Learn the warning signs:

<https://www.nami.org/Learn-More/Know-the-Warning-Signs>

Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration

Information on mental health and substance abuse, hotlines and referrals:

<https://findtreatment.samhsa.gov/>

National Institute on Alcohol Abuse and Alcoholism

<https://www.niaaa.nih.gov/>

National Institute on Drug Abuse

www.drugabuse.gov

Mental Health First Aid online courses

https://www.google.com/url?q=https://www.mentalhealthfirstaid.org/take-a-course/find-a-course/&sa=D&ust=1573971063856000&usg=AFQjCNEsK-LAdgSbroxJNv_ybyG9G54pQ

Contributors

Contributing Shluchim and Shluchos:

Rabbi Chaim Hilel, Cal Polytech

Rabbi Yossi & Manya Lazaroff, Texas A&M University

Rabbi Dov & Shevy Oliver, SUNY Rockland

Rabbi Eliyahu & Shaindy Raskin, Brooklyn Law School

Rabbi Didy Waks, Hamilton College

Rabbi Eitan & Gitty Webb, Princeton University

Contributing professionals:

Carol King Berkman, LCSW, Jewish Family Service

Mendel Horowitz, MS, Clinical Sociology, Private Practice

Terri Kaye Needle, MS, Counseling; Professor of Psychology